ROCK SHELTERS OF KERALAM

INTRODUCTION

Prehistoric art works constitute a vital source for understanding the overall living environment of their times. They are mainly in the form of etchings, paintings and bruises on the surfaces and walls of the rock shelters. While some are identifiable pictures, many others look like symbols and abstract motifs. Whether the prehistoric people had seen them as art or magic is a matter of debate. Nevertheless, it is evident that these depictions relate to the means of subsistence and survival of the people who made them.

Rock art refers to any human-made marking executed on natural stone surfaces. It is also known by various terms, such as cave art, cave paintings, and rock engravings. Rock carvings constitute deliberate human interventions on stone and represent a vital source for understanding the prehistoric culture of a region. Human responses to the objective conditions of existence are expressed through rock carvings, which enable scholars to reconstruct the socio-economic conditions of prehistoric communities. Ancient rock art provides one of the most valuable entry points into the mental world of early human societies. As a non-verbal form of communication, it functioned as a visual language through which ideas were conveyed to people of all ages.

Prehistoric art offers profound insights into prehistoric life, and scholars therefore examine such depictions as crucial sources for reconstructing the social conditions of early human existence. The discovery of prehistoric caves and their associated art was largely accidental, often occurring during game-hunting expeditions by British officials in the colonial period. In Kerala, prehistoric rock art sites were discovered in 1894 by F. Fawcett. Dating prehistoric rock art remains a challenging task, as many representations span a wide chronological range, extending from the prehistoric into the historic period.

India secured a significant place on the global map of prehistoric rock art between 1867 and 1868, following the discoveries of rock art sites in central and northern India by Archibald Carlyle and Cockburn. Carlyle identified paintings at Sohagighat in the Kaimur Hills, located in the present Mirzapur district of Uttar Pradesh. The paintings of the Mirzapur region depict animals such as leopards, bears, deer, and boars, along with representations of flora and water sources. Carlyle observed that some paintings illustrated, in a stiff and archaic style, scenes from the lives of early stone tool-makers, while others portrayed animals and hunting scenes involving men armed with bows and arrows, spears, and hatchets.

India’s most renowned rock art site is Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh. In 1957, the archaeologist Vishnu S. Wakankar discovered rock paintings at this site. Mesolithic art at Bhimbetka and other locations typically represents animals either in isolation or as part of dynamic hunting scenes. The sandstone formations of Bhimbetka comprise 754 numbered rock shelters, of which more than 500 contain paintings attributed to the Mesolithic period. Bhimbetka preserve paintings from the Upper Palaeolithic, Mesolithic, and Chalcolithic periods.

Despite regional variations in style and content, rock art across the world exhibits remarkable similarities in subject matter, technique, and spatial organisation. Animals, hunting scenes, geometric motifs, and human figures recur across continents, pointing to shared cognitive

frameworks and symbolic behaviours among early human societies. Consequently, rock art serves as a crucial archaeological source for understanding prehistoric religion, economy, social organisation, and the evolution of human thought in a global perspective.

ROCK SHELTERS IN KERALAM

Kerala represents the southernmost region of rock art distribution in India. Rock-art from Kerala gained attention of the world with the discovery of rock engraving at Edakkal by Fawcett in 1894 (Fawcett 1901). After this discovery, the study of rock-art in Kerala lay dormant for the next eight decades or so. Rock art studied were revived and received a spurt in Kerala during the early nineteen seventies with the discovery of painted rock shelters at Marayur by S.P.Tampi (Tampi 1983). Over the years, many new sites and writings on various facets of rock-art in Kerala have been brought forth by scholars like, Y. Mathpal (1998), M.R.Warrier (2006), P.Rajendran (2007), R. Gurukkal (2010) and Benny Kurian (2011).

Petroglyphs or rock engravings/carvings is popular mode of rock-art representations in Kerala. They have been reported from south as well as north Kerala. In south, they have been reported from Ankode, and Tenmala, Marayoor region and Ettukuduukka in Kannur Dist., Tovari and Edakkal in Wayanad district and the last site being the most rich and famous. Tovari symbols are similar to Edakkal in treatment and style.

EDAKKAL

Edakkal rock shelter is the most unique and the earliest rock art site to be discovered in Kerala with large number of engravings or etching. This shelter was discovered by Fawcett just 15 years after the historic discovery of the Altamira paintings. The report on the shelter and its engravings by Fawcett is of exemplary nature and there is hardly any facet he left unrecorded or without interpretation. Yet, it happens to be the most discussed rock shelter in academic circles and have been subjected to various studies and interpretations.

Edakkal shelter is located on a hill known as the Ambukuthimala at the elevation of about 4,600 feet above MSL. The shelter has a lower and upper story. The lower story has no engravings and flowing through it is a perennial water stream. The upper story is reached after a steep climb that opens into a landing and to the right of it is an opening leading into a cleft between two rock formations. Between the cleft, on the top, rests a large boulder sheltering the cleaved rock formation, the further end of the cleft to the south is open to the sky. The rock surface on either side of the entrance is engraved or etched with strange looking stylized anthropomorphic figures, animals and other symbolic representations. These anthropomorphic figures though linear in delineation are quite articulate in execution. To attain coordination and best results it appears that the outline of the figure was first drawn and then subsequently etched or grooved out deeper. There are also a few inscriptions in the cave.

The left wall almost in the center has a very prominent anthropomorphic figure with a strange face, headgear and arms. Adjoining it is another figure equally large with a queer circular design at the chest. There are a many more stylized anthropomorphic figures adjoining these, some small and some large. There are also some figures above the larger images in shallow depths

when compared to the larger figures. There animals like dog, elephant, deer/blackbuck, peacock, plant and flowers, a human figure with a hand shaped like a jar among the depictions. A so called 'wheeled cart' with a figure above on the extreme left and a lady with a square headed dead dress on the right end are interesting representations. The large anthropomorphic representations towards the center is apparently the pivotal icon as all other figures animal and human seem to be orientated towards it or placed auxiliary to it.

Spoked-wheels or circles with intersecting lines and some geometric motifs are also noticed at many places along both the walls. Recently, a researcher has identified the circles with cross or 'sun crosses' as death symbols and they were observed to be still in use in sepulchral edifices. There are also three inscriptions on this wall towards the empty space at the far end, which opens to the sky.

The earliest may go to the early historic period. The inscriptions are away from the etching and at an elevated portion where sufficient natural light is available. On the right wall too, there is a large anthropomorphic figure and adjoined by some smaller ones. Towards far end opening to natural light is ladder with an anthropomorphic figure above it. There are few other female figures elegantly carved here apart from animals like blackbuck (Antilope cervicapra), a queer bird with long neck (peacock?) and some inscription with early paleography.

Edakkal Engravings

Among the rock-engraving or etching in Kerala, apart from ones at Edakkal there is nothing much to discuss about. Much has been speculated about Edakkal engravings its methodology, its meaning and date etc., from the time it was first reported. It has been opinioned that Neolithic Celts or Iron implements were used to evecute the engraving. The rock is comparatively soft, engraving could be achieved with any sharp flake or stone as vouched by numerous modern graffiti engraved by visitors. The artist who created the engravings did not attempt its creation as an art work as we perceive it today. It was a reflection of their belief and practices. Its true meaning will never be known save for the interpretations we make of them. Conjecturing and infusing meaning to these enigmatic creations is always a challenging and satisfying pursuit for researches.

The location of Edakkal shelter is awe inspiring and bestows mystic feel even today. Nearly 4 feet of debris from the cave was cleared from the rock shelter soon after its initial discovery by Fawcett. He does not report of any stone artifact of prehistoric context from it. The debris of nearly two feet was also removed from this cave recently in 2010-11 and during the process too no prehistoric stone artifact was found. This clearly shows that the rock shelter was never habited in the true sense but possibly was a place worship and veneration, like a temple by the aboriginals who once inhabited the region as stated by Fawcett. In general, it has been observed that rock art bearing shelters do not yield cultural materials indicating that they were rarely used for habitation and possibly had religious overtones and habited shelters tend to have fewer paintings and engravings.

Fawcett states of the cave being associated with minor goddesses called Mudiampilli and imp called Kuttichattan. It is quite possible they are the authors of the engravings at Edakkal were the

ancestors of the locals who were quite creative in their religious beliefs. They had an affinity for having religious edifies on high hills. They also in case of illness, as and when instructed by their ancestral spirits they made offerings to 'mother of the hill'.

They also practiced ancestor worship and erected megalithic monuments. It is quite possible that the anthropomorphic representations at Edakkal are ancestral spirits/deities/bhutas. It is interesting to note that many of the anthropomorphic figures do not have their feet demarcated clearly. Some commonality however is observed in the coiffure and costumes adorned by these figures and also at times in the delineation or positioning of the hands. There are some female figures which are apparently divinities.

At Edakkal, the varied nature in style and depth noticed in the engravings seem to imply that they were done over different periods of time by different people. It is interesting to note that among the animals black buck accounts for majority of the depictions. It should either mean that the clan represented by this animal was the major contributors or believers of the cult practiced in this shelter or this animal carries some magico-religious significance. Till very recently, the antler of this animal was used by village quacks and healers to cleanse ailing people from the clutches of evil eyes/ spirit and by chanting and blowing into it. They believed the sound emanating from the antlers would drive away evil spirits harboring the body that causes illness. In nearly all pristine societies, illness is attributed to evil forces or spirits that come to harbor in the body rather than internal pathological causes. To get rid of the evil, exorcism came to be exercised. A poignant eradicator of the evil from the possessed in ancient societies used to be the shaman. He in divine trance or altered state of consciousness mediated between the evil forces harboring the sufferer and the super world of spirits/demons/ancestors for cleansing and healing the sufferer. These activities of the shaman in another way also brought together the clan in situation of calamity or social instabilities, natural or individual and played constructive role in cohesively binding the emotional bond within the clan during crisis.

Inscriptions in the caves dating from around 2nd /3rd cent AD to 5th/6th cent AD attests that the cave was not totally lost from public memory and was visited by socially elite people either out of curiosity or reverence. Engravings may have also been done during this period but it difficult to sort them out.

The coiffure and costumes of some of the male and female figures carved in Edakkal have an uncanny similarity with that of Theyyam and Bhuta cult. Fawcett over 100 years ago had drawn similarity of the Edakkal figures with the 'devil dance' of the Tuluvas and Mathpal with those of Theyyam. The similarity of the coiffure and masked facial features and certain adornment on the hands draws great similarity with costumes of various Theyyam forms enacted today. One female figure from Edakkal with a large square shaped head gear balanced by two strings held in either hand, are similar to some of the female Theyyam forms enacted today.

The Anthropomorphic figures at Edakkal are not, human portraiture in the true sense as the figures do not have clear demarcation or detailing of human face or human physiognomy. Edakkal figures have masked faces, elaborate fringed coiffure and costumes like the Theyyam figures.

Apart from the anthropomorphs there are also many votive symbols at Edakkal. One of the interesting depictions is an object which has been opinioned as cart. The circles with spokes adjoining the ladder like object were treated as an attesting factor. If it were a cart, the wheel like element should have been found in all the representations here. However that not is the case. The cart appears to be too large for it to be drawn by humans. However no draft animals like bull or horse finds representation here hence the identification that this representation stand for a cart becomes dubious. It is also a well recorded and interesting to note that no indigenous tribes in Kerala region ventured into rearing cattle of their own.

Some factors like the absence of the so called wheel in all representations and the usual wagon vaulted roof over it to protect the rider and goods and the absence of draft animals in these representations seems indicate that the representation is not of a cart as earlier implied. On the other hand these representations appear to be of symbolic ladder leading to heaven. The iconography of the human figures represented at the end of the ladder is rather different from the large figures carved in the centre of the wall. The figures at the end of the ladder are depicted in a hazy manner with no clear demarcation of the feet as though attuning it with the belief spirits lack feet. The figures also carry some shamanistic characters. Shamans in their state of trance are believed to use poles, ladders, pillars and living trees as vehicles to ascend the heaven to claim humanities place among the divinities. Hence it is obvious that in these depictions there is an obvious connotation to 'ladder to heaven'. Now, weather the figures shown ascending it needs to be identified as a spirit or shaman is subjective.

The concept and belief of mythical ladder as a means to ascend and descend to the heaven is for the transmigration of the soul is found represented in Egyptian art. This belief was prevalent among the ancient Chinese and Australian aboriginals too. This concept of also exists in the religious belief Hindu, Buddhist and Christians. The Biblical concept of Jacob's ladder is an idea of great antiquity finds representation in paintings and sculptures. A Buddha is believed to ascended and descended the heavens using a ladder and this theme is represented in early Buddhist sculptural art at Barhut, Sanchi and Gandhara. It is interesting to note that some burial pots retrieved from megalithic site of Kodumanal (Dist. Erode) and Anakkara (Dist. Palaghat) have this ladder like element etched as a graffiti on their exterior surface.

There are also some symbols that apparently represent vulva or the yoni. It is noticed in also at Tobarihill in Waynad. It has got relationship with the cult of fertility it is believed. The representation of the yoni is a source of health and a charm against evil spirits and forms part of a powerful fertility cult.

Date/Period of Association

It is has been opinioned by some that the Edakkal engravings belong to the Neolithic period taking a clue from the fact that Fawcett has stated of discovering a Neolithic implement 15 km away from Edakkal. One has recently reported from the foot hills too. However used tool or debitage of Neolithic implements have not been found from the shelter proper till date. Neither are there any significant pottery finds. It is also interesting to note that no domesticate ungulate animal finds representation in the cave and possibly a domesticated dog finds representation.

Some scholars have tried to draw similarity between some of the motifs at Edakkkal and those in Harappan culture. The existence of some seemingly similar motifs is nothing more than a mere coincidence and convenient conclusions should not be drawn without accounting for issues of time and space.

At Edakkal, a clue possibly lays the inscriptions engraved in shelter. The inscriptions are located at the top, away from the engraving on the left wall and also occur on the right rock surfaces. The location of the early inscription indicates that the figures were already in existence when the earliest inscriptions here were engraved around the early Chera period (2nd-3rd AD). How early before 2nd Cent.AD were these figures carved is the crux of the issue regarding its date. The figures do not appear to antedate the earliest inscriptions at Edakkal by more than 500 or 600 years. If so, these carvings must have come about in-between c.6th BC and c.3rd BC. Even if we were to hypothetically push back the antiquity by 800 or 900 years from the date of the earliest inscription in the cave it would still not go beyond the first millennium BC. In other words, the Edakkal engravings can only be placed to Iron Age/megalithic/early historic period in Kerala and can possibly be attributed to the ancestors of the people who had dominance in the region and followed the practice of erecting dolmens.

MARAYUR CAVE

Marayur is traditionally known as the Anjunāḍ (Anjunad) Valley because the region historically comprised five major territorial divisions (nāḍus). In early South Indian administrative and cultural geography, nāḍu referred to a local territorial unit consisting of villages, agrarian lands, and associated forest tracts. The term Anju in Malayalam and Tamil means “five,” and hence Anjunāḍ literally denotes “the land of five nāḍus.”

It is situated on the foothills of Anaimalai and Palani Hill tracts, a funnel like valley formed in a varying altitude of 400 to 2500 m AMSL. This area is located in the eastern fringes of Idukki District about 42 km northeast of Munnar, one of the famous tourist destinations of south central Kerala. Topographically this region is seen as elongated spurs separated by extensive ravines to merge with the relatively gentler slopes to the table land of Marayoor-Chinnar and extended up to the low land of Udumelpet. The predominant rock form is Charnockitic gneisses and a variety of gneisses rock. The rock art places in Anjunad Valley may be found in the ragged cliff, hilltops, and hillocks. They are noticeable all over this valley especially along the long strip of river Pambar and its tributaries. The art occurs on the walls and ceilings of rock shelters, open air boulders and pavements of river beds which are located in the vicinity Iron Age-Early Historic monuments.

Regional History

The present-day tribal communities in the Anjunad Valley have a clear distinction for the ‘cave’ and ‘shelter’ in their language. The people in the Anjunad call ‘Ala’ for shelters and ‘Guha’ for caves, respectively. And ‘Ezhuthu’ means writing or paintings; thus they call the shelter or rock surface having paintings or engravings as ‘Ezhuthala’ or Ezhuthupara’ (Para means Rock). Likewise, some of the shelters are known as ‘Patti’ means cattle pens. Since earlier times until now, the tribes in the Anjunad Valley are engaged in cattle rearing. In the historical times they never owned cattle; instead cattle were handed over to them just to look after during the winter by agricultural people living on tablelands. The wage or profit was shared in form of products

and goods in the barter system. Hence, during the rainy season these shelters were used as pens to accommodate cattle for overnight that may normally extend to weeks. Another interesting aspect of these rock shelters in the Chinnar locality is that some of the shelters are known as 'Payeevarum Ala'; meaning those shelters were used for releasing the spirit or ghost from the human body. Sometime people used this shelter as a temporary settlement. Likewise one family in Marayoor Ur Gramam still uses a shelter partially as residence. Now a day these shelters are being used by locals for hunting and resting. The broken pots, grinding and pounding stones and animal bones etc. suggest a clear evidence of occupation. At present, some of these shelters located deep inside the forest are a favorite dwelling of robbers and sandal smugglers.

Previous Study

In 1974 Padmanabhan Tampi undertook a Ph.D. topic by focusing on Marayoor. He discovered three painted rock shelters from the Marayoor region of the Anjunad Valley. These shelters, known as Ezhuthala are situated near Marayoor Town in Koodakkad area of Marayoor forest, Attala in the same forest division of Pallanad area and Pulachikummati Alai, near Chambakkad tribal settlement of Chinnar Wildlife Sanctuary. He also noticed a painted dolmen at Dindikombur on the way to Kanthaloor. It is significant to note that about 14 years prior to Tampi's discovery, Victor Rosner had noted paintings of knives and hooks inside a massive Dolmen. After Tampi's work, there was a lull for rock art research of the Anjunad Valley until Mathpal undertook systematic documentation. Since 1990-2004 more than five rock shelters were discovered by this eco-tourism member which was lead by Mr. Eswaran Alampetti and Dhanushkodi. Although these sites occasionally used to appear in news papers, regional magazines and channels, it did not attract any scholars. It was in 2008, Dr. Rajan Gurukkal made a visit to this area. In recent years the State Department of Archaeology, conducted a systematic survey to document the rock art and megalithic remains of the region (Pers. Comm., Director, State Department, Kerala, 2010-11). N. Nihildas also conducted a number of explorations in the region to discover and document the rock art heritage of Anjunad Valley.

Distribution of Sites

Rock paintings found in Anjunad Valley can be grouped into paintings (pictographs) and engravings (petroglyphs). About 20 rock paintings and more than 4 engravings are noticed so far. Rock paintings are located in different localities of various altitudes. These paintings are found in the hillock, mountain cliffs, close to streams, solitary rocks and cavities. At one site, Chenganperu (dolmen-3 from the northern side of the site) it has been noticed inside dolmens as well. In fact many of the rock shelters in Anjunad Valley are located as a cluster close to the present Hill Pulayans settlements.

Image Analysis

A total 20 rock painted sites and 4 petroglyphs were reported so far from the Anjunad valley. Out of 20 sites, 9 sites were red ochre painted and 9 sites yielded kaolin paintings. Remaining two sites were noticed with the both red and white pigments. Besides this one site of kaolin pigment was noticed from a Dolmen as well. Petroglyphs were also reported but confined to 4 sites only. To understand the sites further, the motifs were divided as animal figures, human/anthropomorphic figures and designs and symbols.

Animal Figures

Animal figures have been noticed from almost all the sites. They comprise of Sambar, Humped bull, Cattle, Nilgai, Elephant, Horse, Lizard, Monkey, Nilgai Thar, Mongoos, etc. Among these Sambar and Bull/Cattle are predominantly seen. Kaolin paintings depict more animals when compared to red ochre and kaolin. While free standing outline motifs are mostly observed in red ochre, in kaolin, they are either in moving posture or free standing along with a men or group of animals. Out of 70 animal motifs recorded, 25 are belonging to red ochre and 45 are of kaolin.

Human/Anthropomorphic Figures

The Anjunad Valley paintings yielded a number of human/anthropomorphic figures in different style and shape. Out of 98 motifs recorded in white pigment 60 human and 38 anthropomorphic figures were noticed. In case of red ochre, out of 13 figures, 7 human and 6 anthropomorphic figures were found. The red ochre motifs occur either singularly or associated with animal motifs. Three bichrome giant human motifs are included in the red ochre category. They are of magnificent size, however, due to the long exposure to the Sun and other human and natural activities are severely damaged these figures. Schematic depictions of T-shaped and stick-like anthropomorphic figures in red colour are unique to the Anjunad Valley in compare to other rock art sites in India.

In white pigments most of the human/anthropomorphic motifs are either men holding weapon or people engaged in some other activities. The largest concentrations of the human motifs were noticed from Attala and Vedanala. At Attala three anthropomorphic figures were noticed with outstretched legs and a protrusion in between legs, and another anthropomorphic figure with drum. The human motifs found inside the dolmen at Chenganperu bear a close stylistic resemblance with the giant human motif at Ezhuthala.

Symbols and Designs

Symbols and designs are the most extensively recorded motifs from the Anjunad Valley. They consist of several abstract motifs, star symbols, geometric designs, tridents, honey comb, hand prints and net designs. The symbols in red and white colour are different in their nature of execution. In red ochre numerous abstract motifs, hand prints and honey combs are predominantly seen. These motifs have been repeatedly painted in most of the shelters in the Anjunad Valley. In white kaolin, a net/thatched hut design is interesting. This motif has been noticed from the three major shelters in the Anjunad Valley. Total 183 motifs were recorded. In this 103 belong to red pigment and the 80 kaolin. It is observed that the red ochre motifs are more in abstracts form thus it indicate some sort of religious resemblance rather than mere subject matter.

Engravings

Petroglyph on rocky platform, stone and boulders are reported from a couple of sites in the Anjunad Valley. In comparison with pictographs, petroglyphs are less in number. They are mainly of geometric designs and non-figurative. Archaeologically speaking, these engravings are noticed within or vicinity of Megalithic sites. However, this sort of line drawings could be still observed among the Anjunad Ur Grama people until last decade. These modern tribal symbols are mostly noticed associated with village temples. They used to make engravings and bruising as part of amusement and rituals.

Methods and Pigment

There are a number of methods or combinations of methods to illustrate the theme in rock art. The rock paintings and petroglyphs are the principle method used. In the case of paintings, mainly red ochre and kaolin are used, whereas petroglyphs might be made by picking or bruising the surface. Supposedly except Jallimala-1 there is no such preparation noticed in the Anjunad Valley.

Red Ochre Paintings

In the rock painting corpus of the Anjunad Valley, thematic analysis and superimpositions of the figures invariably suggests an earlier date to the red ochre colour paintings. Thin outline, thick outline, flat wash and schematic are different styles noticed in the red ochre. In addition to this, some figures like giant human are life size depiction that is filled in with parallel rows of zigzag and lines. The body portion is painted as different compartments as well. But these features are noticed only in life size figures. Along with red ochre, burnt sienna, dark red and crimson colours were also observable. Line drawings and strokes are also noticeable. The motifs like Sambar and giant human figures are finely depicted. The abstract motifs like a snake inner side filled with vertical and horizontal strokes at Nelthinasettu, anthropomorphic figure at Mandayottimala are elegant. To find out the source of the red ochre, a small survey of resource was conducted. Actually the Anjunad Valley contains a number of iron ore sources since the valley has a Charnokitic-gniess outcrop of the Archaean formation. Iron ore is included in the Charnockite group of rocks. The iron ore body is weathered up to a depth of 40 m, resulting in the alteration to varying degrees of hematite. These geological features must have facilitated the unknown painters of the Anjunad Valley to procure hematite nodule. However, without a scientific analysis of the pigment it would difficult to ascertain the components of the pigment.

White/Kaolin Pigments

In the case of kaolin, it is easily available clay in all the districts of Kerala. It is usually white or nearly white and composed essentially of clay minerals of the kaolin group, principally kaolinite. Flat wash, schematic and geometric forms are the major styles used in kaolin paintings. The outline or figures filled in with lines are absent. Most of the figures are schematically represented. Though white is the principle colour used, nature of the surface and exposure of the shelter to sunlight have caused a minor variation in the colour components. White paintings are usually noticed with thick layers or strokes. Recently a study of rock art in the Kurnool caves shows that white pigment does not get preserved as well as red ochre. Thus by observing the relative degree of preservation and brightness, it can suggest some antiquity. This may be barely applicable in the case of the Anjunad Valley, because the figures like rock plantain, rice plant at Attala and human figures at Alapetti are executed with brightness and thick paints; thus it look more recent.

Superimpositions

In the Anjunad Valley, superimposition was observed at five different sites. The first site was Attala, where a succession of kaolin pigments was noticed. At Attala, overlapping has been noticed at five different locations. Here, animals, human and symbols of younger motifs are superimposing fully or partially the older ones. In one cluster of Attala more than three layers of

pigments were noticed. Another important shelter is Ezhuthala (Pathipara). Here, bull, Cattle and Goat are superimposed by three giant human figures.

The first giant motifs which are more in white colour seemed to be superimposed completely by a faded Goat. Other two human motifs are also overlapping the Bull. At Jallimala-1, painting of stick-like men seated on animal facing each other is superimposed on a red ochre surface. It is assumed that the red painting might have been rubbed off intentionally or faded. Thus the red ochre in the Anjunad Valley is ascribed to an earlier date. Similarly another evidence of a partially overlapping painting in barely visible white pigment was noticed from Chinnavendru. All these point out that, though the superimpositions are a few in the rock art of the Anjunad Valley, existing evidence suggest that the red ochre painting has a longer tradition than the white pigments. It also indicates a cultural overlap or transition among the people practicing paintings in the region.

Rock Art and Megaliths

In the Anjunad Valley, certain features might be connected with the rock art and Megaliths. Irrespective of altitude and position, the rock shelter paintings are located either within or in the immediate vicinity of the burial grounds, ranging maximum 100 m to 2 km radius. Both the red ochre and white kaolin pigments are invariably found associated to the burial grounds. Pictographs are solely seen associated to the dolmen sites. However, no homogeneity in colour of painting is seen associated with the typology or architecture of the dolmens. For instance, at Muruganpara we see red ochre paintings along with architecturally refined style dolmens, whereas in Alampetti we find red ochre and white paintings in the proximity of low type and chambered dolmens.

At Alampetti and Vazhathura, sporadic engravings were found within the dolmen sites. However, on the bank of Athiodai at Chinnar two unidentifiable engravings were reported. Nevertheless, its actual contexts are yet to be ascertained. Apparently the engraved cross hatch design at Alampetti can be observed in the paintings as well. At Jallimala, a rock shelter located close to the Alampetti dolmen site has yielded superimposition of white painting on red ochre. A schematic red symbol is superimposed by white painted animal raiders approaching face to face.

Perhaps this depiction would be a clear indication of the cultural succession of two different period or group of people in the same cultural epoch. Also overlapping red painting by the white would suggest an earlier date to the red ochre. Paintings of a number of hand imprints in nearby dolmen sites at Vannanthurai and Alampetti might be a symbolism or religious practice during the Iron Age-Early Historic time. Except two or three shelters, no floor deposits in Anjunad Valley rock shelters were noticed.

Lack of floor deposit, less number of motifs, appearance of similar motifs repeatedly in different shelters might point to ritualistic significance of the shelters probably in the Iron-Age Early Historic period.

Interestingly discovery of a painted dolmen at Cheganperu perhaps indicate the continuity of this tradition. The small white painted motif looks very similar to the giant human motif of Ezhuthala. Similarly Tampi (1983) and Rosner (1959) had also reported painted dolmen at

Dindukombur and Nachivayal of the Anjunad Valley. Recent excavations conducted in the rock shelter at Muruganpara gave a fairly good evidence of the Early Historic material from the upper strata. In South India, especially in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, the Iron Age-Early Historic cultures are invariably inter-connected.

Relative Chronology

On the basis of style and theme the red ochre paintings in the Anjunad can be divided into two stages. In the first stage the motifs executed in outline are realistic depictions. In the first category of outline, mostly Sambar deer is represented. Other animals noticed in outline are mounting Nilgai, trapped pig, tortoise and fish; all belong to omnivorous, herbivorous, reptile and aquatic groups. These motifs are sometimes painted in isolation or in a group of two to three. They are rarely associated with symbols and designs. The symbols like hand prints might belong to this stage. There is no hunting scene noticed at this stage. The only human activity noticed at this stage is a pig trapped in a loop. There is homogeneity in the motifs in terms of style, colour and theme and an inter-site assimilation is also evident.

In the second stage motifs executed in flat wash such as cattle and humped bull are noticed. The overlapping of three giant human figures on cattle and humped bull would be a cultural succession or an activity in the same cultural realm of where the former motifs belonged to. The occurrence of cattle and bulls superimposed by giant human figures at Ezhuthala, a hunting scene at Jallimala-2, banana harvesting at Chinnavendru, urn/basket at Nelthinasettu and a large number of symbols and abstract motifs illustrate a change in the way of life of the people.

To correlate this cultural trait with the archaeological data to establish a chronological sequence is a challenging task. Therefore, a comparative study of the Anjunad Valley rock art with other region is required. On the basis of the style and theme, the first stage of painting can be proposed to be the emergence of a society with more semi nomadic or hunting- food gathering mode of life. It may be considered that cattle rearing did not become so popular or it was not aboriginal practice of painters. In contrast to this, the motifs in the second stage invariably delineate the emergence of cattle domestication and agriculture along with the continuing practice of small game hunting. A significant change noticed in the second stage was the surfacing of kaolin paintings. The kaolin paintings were rich in subject matter than red ochre ones. Apart from abstract style, hunting, fighting, dancing and other cultural scenes like cart pulling were noticed for the first time in the kaolin paintings. Another important facet was development of anthropomorphic figures. At this stage solely appearing anthropomorphic figures started being depicted with different objects like weapons and drums.

All the rock shelter paintings are noticed in the close vicinity of dolmen sites. They are not only easily approachable but also visual accessible. Their peculiar selections of location, subject matter are very much similar to the many of the rock shelters found in the Western Ghats and Tamil Nadu. Further the subject matter, style, technique and location of these paintings suggested they must not be antedate Iron Age-Early Historic culture. Recent excavation conducted in the Anjunad Valley has also shown the similar feature. There was no conclusive material evidence to ascertain the time of paintings, however, on the basis of style of motifs and cultural materials like potsherds and chert blade the paintings might belong to the Iron Age-Early Historic period.

Rock art is an important cultural trait which gives a direct link to the socio-economic life of bygone people. Kerala is one of the regions in the country where less number of rock art site have been reported. According to some scholars rare occurrence of rock art in Kerala is due to prolonged monsoon that perhaps washes out the paintings or there is possibility of preference to engravings rather than paintings. The Anjunad Valley falls in the rain shadow region of the Southern Western Ghats. In Anjunad Valley, paintings are noticeable on the cliffs, rock cavities and shelters located at the foothills. They are of white kaolin and red ochre pigment. The red ochre motifs are executed in outlines of natural depictions. The red ochre pigment was mainly used to draw Sambar Deer, honey combs, hand impressions and various symbols and signs. Some of the shelters like Mandayottimala, Nelthinesettu have evidence of anthropomorphic figures in red ochre. Cattle were depicted only at the site of Ezhutala. Along with Cattle, Humped Bull and life size human figures are also noticed. It is observed that in red ochre pigment were found more number of animal depiction and humans were less in number.

The visual accessibility of Megalithic remains associated with rock art is very conspicuous in the Anjunad Valley. These shelters are open to a wide range of landscape. The locational analysis of rock art sites and Megaliths show that these are located either within or in the immediate vicinity of the burial grounds, ranging within maximum 100 m to 2 km radius. Both the red ochre and white kaolin pigments are invariably found associated with the burial grounds.

The Anjunad Valley has also witnessed a number of similarities and relations as far as the rock art tradition in south India is concerned. The subject matter, location and occurrence of other cultural remains with paintings in Tamil Nadu and Anjunad Valley share more or less similar features. The rock shelter sites reported from Kodaikanal region are more identical to the paintings of Anjunad Valley. Alike Anjunad Valley they are also located in the vicinity of Iron Age monuments. The subject matter is hunting scenes, man sitting and standing on animals, dancing scenes and fighting scenes etc. On the basis of available data of typology of the Iron Age monuments, location of painted rock shelter, similarity in thematic representation suggest a cultural expansion of this painting practicing community located in the southern Western Ghats of Palani-Anjunad Valley regions. Further the local legend in the Anjunad Valley suggests that people in this Valley had migrated during the unrest in the Madurai Coimbatore region of historical time. Perhaps the war motifs in kaolin are nothing but the later exemplification of this social instability. Thus continuous cultural sequence of the paintings of Anjunad Valley can be proposed probably from the Iron Age to the medieval period. However further problem oriented studies like ethnographic parallels and location analysis along with attempts for absolute date will be required to confirm this hypothesis.

ANCODE CAVE

Ancode, locally known as Pandavanpara, is situated at an elevation of approximately 1,000 feet above sea level in Perumkadavila village of Neyyattinkara Taluk, in Thiruvananthapuram District. Prior to the rule of Marthanda Varma, Ancode was also known by the name Thenganad. Pandavanpara is a monumental rock formation of impressive scale, characterised by a granite, pagoda-like natural structure facing west

The terrain is particularly conducive to early human habitation and seasonal camping. The rock formation extends to nearly 100 metres in length with an approximate slope of 60 degrees. Geomorphologically, the site represents a dyke-type formation with flattened stone alignments undergoing rapid weathering. The rock surface is highly weathered and comparable to that of Tovari, making it especially suitable for deep engravings.

The Ancode cave complex is rich in archaeological remains, including numerous rock art panels and dolmens. It is regarded as one of the earliest centres of rock engravings and proto-script traditions in the region. The first systematic attempt to date the Ancode cave was undertaken by P. Rajendran. The petroglyphs found at the site provide valuable insights into the material life and cultural practices of prehistoric communities. The presence of a nearby dolmen further indicates the continuity of occupation from the Mesolithic into the Megalithic period.

These archaeological remains constitute crucial sources for reconstructing the lifeways of prehistoric and megalithic populations, shedding light on their cultural expressions, subsistence patterns, and artistic skills.

The Ancode cave is richly endowed with a large number of petroglyphs. The engravings include decorative floral motifs on the entrance wall, a limited number of human figures, geometric patterns, and sun symbols in the interior sections of the cave. These rock art remains provide valuable insights into the material milieu and subsistence practices of prehistoric communities.

The Ancode cave has been studied in detail by Yashodhar Mathpal and P. Rajendran. The rock surface at Ancode is particularly suitable for deep engraving, owing to its weathered nature. The engravings measure approximately 1.9 cm in depth and 1.5 cm in width, and could have been executed using sharp stone tools, possibly resembling Neolithic hand axes or stone flakes. The petroglyphs of Ancode are broadly classified into two categories: symbolic imagery and anthropomorphic imagery. Symbolic imagery includes geometric forms such as triangles, rectangles, and circles, along with floral motifs, sun symbols, and inscriptions resembling Vattezhuthu script. Anthropomorphic imagery consists primarily of human figures depicted in hunting postures, armed with bows and arrows.

SYMBOLIC IMAGERIES

The outer face of the shelter at Ancode displays twenty-one cross-hatched engravings arranged vertically and horizontally, overlapping one another. On the interior side wall, several engraved motifs are visible, including a hexagonal floral design, a series of linear patterns, and a rectangular motif internally divided into eight compartments. In addition, a single character resembling the letter *‘nu’* of the Vattezhuthu/Malayalam script is observed. This character appears in close association with a floral motif and is technically and stylistically similar, suggesting that both belong to the same chronological phase.

Only a limited number of distinctive motifs are present at the site, such as the crossed-circle symbol, the herringbone pattern, and the palm-leaf–like motif. These motifs exhibit strong stylistic and technical uniformity, indicating a coherent artistic tradition.

The petroglyphs of Edakkal Guha comprise both geometric and non-geometric motifs, in addition to floral and faunal representations. Comparable geometric symbols are also evident among the Ancode petroglyphs. Similarly, the rock shelter at Tenmalai displays geometric forms such as circles, triangles, and floral motifs, closely resembling those found at Ancode. The etchings at Tovari are relatively shallow and include motifs such as circles, triangles, squares, and their various combinations, many of which find parallels in the Ancode cave.

The rock shelter at Attala, located in Marayur, contains over 400 painted representations on its walls and ceilings, all executed in white pigment. These motifs include depictions of a mountain goat suckling its young, lizards, reptiles, birds, and geometric figures such as rectangles and triangles. Comparable geometric motifs are also present in the Ancode cave.

The portrayals at Ancode are characterised by deeply incised petroglyphs, closely resembling the engraving technique observed at the Tovari cave. Together, these stylistic and technical parallels suggest a shared regional rock art tradition within Kerala, marked by continuity in motif selection and execution across multiple sites.

ANTHROPOMORPHIC IMAGERIES

Anthropomorphic imagery is relatively rare in the engravings of Ancode. The few human figures present are depicted in hunting postures, equipped with bows and arrows, clearly indicating engagement in hunting-and-gathering subsistence activities.

In contrast, the Koodakkad site in the Marayur region contains three monumental anthropomorphic figures. These figures are outlined in red ochre and filled internally with white wavy lines. Their physiognomy is highly stylised: the palms of the hands and facial features are not distinctly rendered, and consequently, these figures cannot be regarded as realistic human portraits in the strict sense. Rather, they appear to represent symbolic or ritualised human forms.

Similarly, at Pallanad, there are depictions of human figures shown riding in a procession and carrying an object resembling a decorated pole. Such representations suggest ceremonial or collective activities, marking a thematic shift from subsistence-oriented imagery towards more complex social or ritual expressions.

The portrayals at Ancode consist of deeply incised petroglyphs. However, there is no associated stratigraphic or contextual evidence at the site that would allow for a reliable chronological attribution of the engravings. The archaeological debris in the area has been extensively disturbed, thereby eliminating the possibility of systematic excavation. Moreover, a fresh assessment of the petroglyphs is no longer feasible, as the engraved surfaces have been severely damaged and, in many instances, completely chipped away.

Material Life and Symbolic Expression in the Rock Art of Ancode Cave

At Ancode, a range of symbolic imagery is observed, including geometric patterns such as rectangles and crossed circles; floral motifs, notably the hexagonal flower and palm-leaf–like designs; sun symbols; and a character resembling the letter *‘nu’* of the Vattezhuthu script. In addition, an anthropomorphic image depicting a human figure armed with a bow and arrow has been engraved on the cave surface.

The petroglyphs of the Ancode cave—comprising both symbolic and anthropomorphic imagery—constitute significant representations of the socio-economic conditions of the communities that once inhabited the site. These engravings effectively inscribe aspects of everyday life and cultural practices onto the rock surfaces of the cave. The rock art, petroglyphs, and associated dolmens together form the sole archaeological evidence for the presence of prehistoric populations at Ancode. During this period, rock art functioned as a primary medium through which communities expressed their material milieu of subsistence and social experience. Chert stone tools were likely employed in the execution of the petroglyphs at Ancode, reflecting the technological capabilities of the prehistoric inhabitants.

Anthropomorphic imagery in cave art provides valuable insights into the lifeways of hunting-and-gathering societies. Hunting scenes occur frequently across all stylistic phases of Mesolithic rock art, indicating the centrality of hunting activities in prehistoric subsistence strategies. Animal trapping and hunting constituted the primary economic activities of Mesolithic communities, and the recurrent depiction of bows and arrows serves as clear evidence of these practices. Such representations reflect the technological means employed by hunters in securing food resources.

Hunting-and-gathering societies did not possess rigidly demarcated or exclusively defended territories. Instead, each group operated within a set of socially recognised principles that governed access to essential material resources required for subsistence. These communities sustained themselves through the collection of edible fruits, roots, and honey, supplemented by the hunting of small animals. The material culture associated with these activities finds visual expression in rock art, which thus becomes a crucial medium for understanding prehistoric economic organisation.

The consistent portrayal of such weapons in prehistoric art reflects not only subsistence activities but also the symbolic and cultural dimensions of hunting in early human societies.

Religious Concepts Reflected in the Petroglyphs of Ancode Cave

A range of geometric symbols can be observed in the Ancode cave, including crossed circles, rectangles, and vertical and horizontal linear motifs. These geometric signs are interpreted as representations of religious concepts. Symbols such as the cross and the triangle appear to have developed from primary forms familiar to prehistoric communities, particularly in the context of tool manufacture, while circles may be regarded as tertiary symbols arising from more complex cognitive processes.

The repeated occurrence of motifs such as triangles and rectangles indicates that these forms were not arbitrary but imbued with functional, spiritual, or ritual significance. Geometric designs in rock art across the world reveal not only the cognitive development of prehistoric societies but also their belief systems and mystical worldviews. Religious conceptions concerning the nature of the universe and humanity’s place within it thus played an important role in sustaining both individual life and social order.

The triangular motif, commonly found in rock art worldwide, is often interpreted as a symbolic representation of the primordial mother associated with fertility and creation. Defined by three

intersecting lines connecting three points, the triangle is a rigid and unalterable geometric form. Rectangular motifs are also present in the Ancode cave; unlike triangles, rectangles and squares are structurally flexible and can be transformed into other shapes. Together, these geometric forms embody economic and cultural ideas that shed light on prehistoric life in the region and were likely created to serve specific purposes connected with popular beliefs relating to health, prosperity, and social well-being.

TENMALAI SHELTER

Tenmalai shelter in Kollam district has engravings of few geometrical patterns like triangles, circles, squares, flower motifs, and circle with cross marks. There are also parallel lines. Rajendran claims to have found Mesolithic artifacts from a depth of 35 cm from floor of the cave and also has a date of 5000 BP for a wood charcoal from the shelter. Whether the rock engravings and the microliths - found nearly a foot below the soil belongs to the same period is a subject for deliberations.

ETTUKUDUKKA

Ettukudukka (12º 17 N; 75° 17E) in Kannur district has humped bull figurines facing east engraved on a lateritic rock bed, close to tank there. It is believed that it was a cattle rearing area and the tank was a water source for grazing animals. It is interesting to note that stylistically similar bull figurines have been observed in South Maharashtra, Goa and Costal Karnataka region. It possibly indicates of some migrational trail of cattle raisers.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, the rock art tradition of Kerala—represented by sites such as Edakkal Caves, Marayur Rock Paintings, Ancode Cave, Tenmala Rock Art, and Ettukudukka Cave—reflects a long chronological span extending from the late Mesolithic and Neolithic phases through the Iron Age and into the early historic period. The stylistic sequence from simple linear and geometric motifs to more complex anthropomorphic, zoomorphic, and symbolic representations suggests cultural continuity as well as transformation over time. While the petroglyphs of Edakkal indicate multiple phases of activity, possibly including early historic inscriptions and symbols, the rock paintings of Marayur and the southern Kerala sites point to hunter-gatherer and early agro-pastoral communities inhabiting the forested landscapes of the Western Ghats. Collectively, these sites demonstrate that rock art in Kerala was a sustained cultural practice deeply embedded in ritual, memory, and landscape, offering crucial chronological and cultural insights into the prehistoric and protohistoric development of South India and underscoring the need for systematic dating, documentation, and conservation.

Model Questions

Maximum Time: 2Hours **Maximum Marks 70**

Section A

Short Answer Questions

Answer All Questions. Each Question Carries 3 Marks

(Ceiling 24 Marks)

1. Define prehistoric rock art.
2. What are petroglyphs?
3. Distinguish between pictographs and petroglyphs.
4. Who discovered the Edakkal rock shelter and in which year?
5. Anthropomorphic imagery
6. What are the major motifs found in the Edakkal engravings?
7. Mention the important animal figures represented in Marayur rock art.
8. What is superimposition in rock paintings?
9. Explain the relationship between rock art and Megalithic culture in Keralam.
10. What are geometric motifs in rock art? Give examples from Keralam.

Section B Short Essay

Answer Any 8 Questions. Each Question Carries 6 Marks

(Ceiling 36 Marks)

1. Critically analyse the claim that Edakkal was a ritual centre rather than a habitation site?
2. Discuss the importance of prehistoric art in reconstructing prehistoric life.
3. Analyse the anthropomorphic figures of Edakkal and their cultural significance.
4. Explain the religious and ritual interpretations associated with Edakkal engravings.
5. Describe the major themes represented in the rock paintings of Marayur.
6. Explain the symbolic and geometric motifs found in Ancode cave.
7. Analyse the anthropomorphic depictions of Ancode and Marayur.
8. Discuss the evidence for hunting-and-gathering subsistence reflected in rock art.
9. Discuss the role of rock art as a visual language in prehistoric societies.
10. Compare the rock engravings of Edakkal with those of Tenmalai and Ancode.

Section C Essay Questions

Answer Any One of the Following Questions

1X 10 = 10 Marks

1. Critically evaluate the archaeological and cultural significance of the Edakkal rock shelter.
2. Discuss the distribution, themes, and chronology of rock art sites in Keralam.
3. Examine the relationship between rock art, Megalithic culture in Keralam.
4. Analyse the socio-economic life of prehistoric communities as reflected in the rock art of Keralam.
5. Evaluate the significance of symbolic and anthropomorphic imagery in rock art traditions.
6. Compare and contrast the rock art traditions of Edakkal, Marayur, and Ancode.
7. Examine the problems of dating prehistoric rock art in Keralam and evaluate the methods used by scholars to establish chronology.